

BEGE-141 UNDERSTANDING PROSE ASSIGNMENT

(FOR JULY 2025 AND JANUARY 2026 SESSIONS)

BA English Honours & General

(Based on Blocks 1-4)

- Can be read as Model answers for understanding.
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Section A

Write short notes on the following in about 200 words each:

1. Difference between Metaphor and Simile

A **simile** is a way of comparing **two different things** using words like “**like**” or “**as**”. It shows that the two things are similar, but they are still separate. For example, “**Her eyes are like stars**” compares eyes to stars clearly. Sometimes, similes can be more detailed and creative, and these are called **conceit** or **epic simile**.

A metaphor is a figure of speech in which one thing is described as if it were another, without using “like” or “as,”. It creates a more imaginative meaning. For example, if Robert Burns said, “O my love is a **red, red rose**,” it is a metaphor. Another simple example is, “Time is a **thief**,” where **time** is compared to a thief.

In a metaphor, the thing we are describing is called the **tenor** (like “my love” or “time”), and the image used to describe it is called the **vehicle** (like “rose” or “thief”). Metaphors can also use **verbs** and **adjectives** in a figurative way, like Shakespeare: “How sweet the **moonlight sleeps** upon this bank.”

In short, a **simile** uses “like/as” to compare things, while a **metaphor** says one thing **is** another.

2. Characteristics of Descriptive Prose

Descriptive prose is a type of **literary writing** that describes **people, places, objects, or events** in detail. Its main goal is to create **clear and vivid images** in the reader’s mind. Unlike poetry, prose is written in **continuous sentences** without line breaks or a regular meter.

One important feature is **careful observation**. Writers describe colors, shapes, sounds, smells, and emotions to make the scene come alive. The language is usually expressive, precise, and rich, often using adjectives, similes, and metaphors to enhance the description.

As **John Dryden** said, well-written prose, which he called “**that other harmony of prose,**” is **no less an art than good poetry**. This means that careful prose can be beautiful and artistic, with rhythm and balance in its sentences, even though it is not verse. Dryden also noted that artful prose developed later than poetry in many literatures, showing its special literary value.

Descriptive prose may appear in narrative, expository, or expressive writing, but its main purpose is to help the reader see, feel, and experience what is described. In short, it combines clarity, vivid imagery, and style to create a rich and engaging picture.

3. Diary Writing

A diary is a personal record where a writer regularly notes their thoughts, feelings, experiences, and daily events. It is usually written in first person, making it intimate and private. Diary writing allows the writer to reflect, express emotions, and preserve memories. It is often informal in tone, using simple language that captures personal reactions and observations.

Features of a diary include **date-wise entries**, honesty, self-expression, and a focus on personal experiences rather than general facts. Diaries may also include **letters, sketches, or clippings** to make them more expressive.

There are different **types of diaries**: **personal diaries**, which record everyday life; **travel diaries**, which describe journeys and places visited; and **literary diaries**, where writers reflect on life, ideas, or society.

For example, **Samuel Pepys’ Diary (1660–1669)** provides detailed accounts of 17th-century England, including events like the **Great Fire of London (1666)**. Another famous example is **Anne Frank’s Diary (1942–1944)**, written while hiding during the **Holocaust**. Her diary not only records her daily life but also captures her **fears, hopes, and reflections** on humanity.

In short, **diary writing** is a **personal, reflective, and expressive form of prose**, giving readers insight into the writer’s mind while preserving moments of life for the future.

4. Hyperbole and Litotes

Hyperbole is a figure of speech where we exaggerate something to make it sound much bigger, stronger, or more extreme. It is used to create a strong effect, either serious, funny, or dramatic. For example, saying, “I’m so hungry I could eat a whole elephant!” is **hyperbole**. It exaggerates hunger to make it sound extreme.

The famous writers like Ben Jonson and Andrew Marvell also used **hyperbole** in poems to praise or create irony. **Hyperbole** is also seen in everyday speech, like “I’ve told you a million times!”

The opposite of **hyperbole** is **understatement**, which downplays something, making it seem less important. A special type of **understatement** is called **litotes**, which expresses a positive idea by negating its opposite. For example, “He’s not the brightest student in class” actually means he is not smart. **Litotes** often create a humorous or ironic effect, and they were common in older literature, such as in *Beowulf*, where a dangerous place is described simply as, “That is not a pleasant place.”

Overall, **hyperbole** exaggerates, while **litotes** understates or negates to make a point. Both are useful for expressing feelings vividly.

Section B

Answer the following questions in about 350 words each:

1. Examine how Orwell critiques British imperialism through his portrayal of the English in colonial Burma in “Shooting an Elephant.”

The concept of British imperialism is the domination of other countries by Britain, where the British controlled the land, people, and resources of the colonized nations. In his essay “*Shooting an Elephant*” (1936), George Orwell discusses the English in colonial Burma by showing their life as officers of the Empire, caught between power and fear. George Orwell served in the ‘Indian Imperial Police’ in Burma in the 1920s, and he uses his personal experience to expose the contradictions of imperialism.

Orwell shows that the English are not truly free. They are constantly watched and judged by the locals, and their authority depends on maintaining appearances. The essay discusses how he was hated by many Burmese people, and even small actions could provoke mockery or insult. The English officers lived in constant tension, duality of power, they hated the system they served but were forced to act as its enforcers. Orwell confesses that he secretly supported the Burmese

against the British rulers, yet he had to perform his duties to avoid being laughed at or losing respect. This reveals the **hollowness of British power**, it is more about image than genuine control.

The ‘shooting’ of the elephant becomes a powerful metaphor for imperialism itself. Orwell did not want to kill the elephant, but the expectations of the Burmese crowd pushed him to act against his own judgment. Here, Orwell critiques the English officers as **puppets of the Empire**: they appear to dominate, yet they are controlled by the pressures of the colonized population and the expectations of their role.

The essay also shows the moral and emotional cost of imperialism. Orwell feels guilt, fear, and frustration, demonstrating that imperialism harms both the oppressors and the oppressed. This is similar to **Frantz Fanon’s** observation about colonial oppression. As Frantz Fanon notes, colonialism dehumanizes both the oppressed and the oppressor, a duality vividly illustrated in Orwell’s experience in Burma.

Through vivid narrative, descriptive details, and personal reflection, Orwell portrays the English in Burma as trapped in a system they cannot fully control, forced to act against their conscience. “*Shooting an Elephant*” critiques British imperialism by showing its oppressive, dehumanizing effects and the way it corrupts both the rulers and the ruled.

2. What does The Diary of a Young Girl reveal about the Holocaust and the psychological trauma endured by the Jewish community?

The Diary of a Young Girl (1947), written by Anne Frank, reveals the terrible reality of the Holocaust. The Holocaust was the systematic killing of Jewish people by Nazi Germany during World War II. As a result, the Jewish community suffered deep psychological trauma. It shows how a young Jewish girl lived in fear and isolation when the Nazis hunted and persecuted Jews during World War II. Anne’s diary is important because it tells us about the pain, struggles, and hopes of Jews who were hiding to save their lives.

Anne Frank, a Jewish girl, went into hiding with her family in a secret place called the ‘Secret Annexe’ in Amsterdam. This was to escape Nazi persecution. Her diary describes the harsh laws that Jews faced, such as having to wear a yellow star, being banned from public places, and being forced to attend separate Jewish schools. The diary shows how life became hard with limited freedom and constant fear of arrest or death. For example, Anne writes about how Jews were captured and sent to terrible camps or ghettos, often never to return.

Psychologically, the diary reveals the mental suffering that Anne and other Jews went through. Anne expresses her feelings of loneliness, fear, and hope. She talks about being scared of air raids and the tension inside the secret hiding place among the people living together in small rooms. At times, she feels sad and depressed, but she also shows courage and a strong will to survive. Writing in her diary was a way for Anne to cope with the trauma and not lose hope. For instance, she says writing helped her to “shake off everything” and bring back her courage.

Moreover, Anne’s diary shows the impact of constant stress on relationships. Her bond with her mother was difficult, and there was tension among those in hiding. Yet Anne also showed love for her family and friends, especially her close relationship with her father. In the diary, Anne's growth from a child to a thoughtful young girl is visible as she reflects on her experiences and dreams of a better future despite the horror around her.

In conclusion, The Diary of a Young Girl reveals the harsh realities of the Holocaust, the fear, loss, and suffering faced by Jewish people. It also shows the psychological trauma of living under constant threat and hiding with limited freedom. Anne’s diary is a powerful witness to history and a reminder of the resilience of the human spirit in the darkest times. It helps us understand the cruelty of the Holocaust and the courage of those who lived through it.

3. Anton Chekhov’s story “Misery” explores human indifference toward others’ suffering.

Anton Chekhov’s short story “*Misery*” (1886), also known by the subtitle “*To Whom Shall I Tell My Grief?*”, explores human indifference towards another person’s suffering. The story shows how people are so absorbed in their own lives that they fail to notice the deep pain of others.

The main character, Iona Potapov, is an old sledge-driver who has recently lost his son. His grief is unbearable, and he wants to share it with someone so that his heart can feel lighter. Chekhov describes his condition with the question: “*To whom shall I tell my grief?*” This question runs throughout the story and expresses Iona’s loneliness.

First, Iona tries to talk to an army officer who hires his sledge. He says, “*My son... my son died this week, sir.*” However, the officer, being busy and impatient, does not respond with sympathy. Instead, he tells Iona to hurry up and drive properly. This shows how people often fail to listen when someone around them is suffering.

Later, three young men sit in his sledge. They laugh, joke, and insult Iona, but when he again mentions his son’s death, they ignore him. The hunchback among them only replies casually,

"We shall all die." This response shows indifference rather than compassion. Even when Iona talks to a young cabman in the resting place, the man falls asleep without listening.

In the end, Iona pours out his sorrow to his little mare, his horse. He tells her, *"That's how it is, old girl... Kuzma Ionitch is gone. He went and died for no reason."* The mare cannot speak, but her silent presence comforts him more than human beings do.

Through this story, Chekhov highlights that grief becomes heavier when there is no one willing to share it. The title *"Misery"* is appropriate because Iona's pain is not only from his son's death but also from people's coldness. The story reveals the harsh truth that human beings are often self-centered and indifferent. Chekhov makes us reflect on the importance of listening and showing kindness to others who are silently suffering.

4. Discuss how this theme is developed in the narrative. Compare Jamaica Kincaid's perception of England as a child with her experience of the country as an adult.

In her essay *"On Seeing England for the First Time"* (1991), Jamaica Kincaid shows how her feelings about England changed from childhood to adulthood. As a child in Antigua, she was taught to see England as something holy, beautiful, and superior. But when she finally visited England as an adult, her experience was filled with anger, disappointment, and rejection.

As a child, Kincaid first saw England on a map in her classroom. She describes how the map showed England "delicately, a very special jewel," and her teacher presented it with "authority, seriousness, and adoration." This shows how colonial education made children worship England almost like a sacred land. She even compares England to Jerusalem, saying, "It was as if she had said, 'This is Jerusalem, the place you will go to when you die but only if you have been good.'" Through these words, we see how England was turned into a myth for colonized children.

Her daily life also carried England's presence. Everything she used, her breakfast, clothes, shoes, even her father's felt hat, was stamped with the label "Made in England." She recalls that the only things not made in England were "the sea, the sky, and the air we breathed." As a result, young Kincaid felt erased, with no identity of her own. She admits, "I had long ago been conquered." This shows the deep psychological effect of colonialism.

However, as an adult, when she finally traveled to England, the reality was very different. The idea of England that filled her childhood did not match the actual place. She found England ugly, its food tasteless, and its weather harsh. Even the famous "white cliffs of Dover" disappointed her. She writes that when she saw them, "they were not that pearly, majestic thing I used to sing

about.” Instead of love or respect, she was filled with “hatred” and a desire to “tear it into little pieces.”

Thus, the theme is developed through contrast. Childhood Kincaid saw England as a shining myth created by colonial power, while adult Kincaid experienced England as ordinary, disappointing, and oppressive. This shift reveals her journey from colonized admiration to postcolonial anger.

SECTION C

Answer the following questions in about 600 words each:

- 1. How does Jawaharlal Nehru offer a deeper understanding of Indian culture and civilization in “The Quest of Man”?**

The letter “*The Quest of Man*” was written by Jawaharlal Nehru to his daughter Indira Gandhi from Dehra Dun jail in 1932. The letter is part of *Glimpses of World History*. Through this letter, Nehru gives not just a history lesson but also a deep reflection on man’s journey, knowledge, and culture. By doing so, he offers a wider understanding of Indian culture and civilization.

The letter begins with Nehru describing his prison life. He writes about “the cool night air” and the “trees that overlook them are greener.” Even in jail, he connects with nature. This shows the Indian cultural tradition of finding joy and meaning even in suffering. Instead of bitterness, Nehru shows calmness and a philosophical outlook. This attitude itself reflects India’s spiritual strength.

The letter then moves to history. Nehru tells his daughter that he wants to “place vivid images of the past before you” so that she can see “how the river of history has run on from age to age.” By using the image of a flowing river, Nehru reflects an Indian way of seeing history as a continuous journey. Indian civilization has always valued continuity of culture, from the Vedas to modern times. Nehru tries to pass on this vision to Indira.

The letter also shows how curiosity shaped man’s progress. Nehru writes that man was different from animals because he had “a mind, curiosity, the desire to find out and learn.” He compares man to “a little baby” who asks endless questions. This simple example shows that the quest for knowledge is natural. In Indian civilization, **this quest is seen in the Upanishads**, where thinkers asked questions about the self and the universe. Nehru reminds Indira of this tradition when he quotes the old philosophers: “Know thyself.”

The letter further shows that Indian culture has always tried to connect the outer world and the inner world. Nehru explains that man's quest has two directions: one to understand nature, and the other to understand himself. He says, "The quest is really one and the same, for man is part of Nature." This thought reflects the Indian idea of harmony between man and the universe. Ancient Indian philosophy, such as the Vedas and the Upanishads, also taught that the self (Atman) is connected with the larger universe (Brahman). Nehru brings this cultural wisdom into a modern form for his daughter.

The letter also compares religion and science. Nehru says, "Religion has attempted to give a complete and dogmatic answer... Science gives a doubting and hesitating reply." Here he shows his preference for reason and scientific thought. At the same time, he respects the spiritual tradition of India which asks deep questions. Indian civilization has always had both: spiritual inquiry and rational debates. For example, Buddhism and Jainism questioned rituals, while philosophers like Charvakas argued for reason. Nehru connects this old tradition with modern science. Thus, he presents Indian civilization as open-minded, questioning, and balanced.

The letter also warns about misuse of knowledge. Nehru says, "Science itself has been used by him chiefly to supply him with terrible weapons." This shows his concern that man may destroy his own civilization. Indian culture too has often stressed the need for right use of knowledge. The idea of dharma in Indian civilization means using power and wisdom for good, not for harm. Nehru continues this ethical vision in his letter.

The prose style of Nehru also helps us understand Indian civilization. His letter is simple, direct, and conversational. He writes as if he is talking to his daughter: "I suppose I shall still continue... the joy that the thought of you gives me when I sit down to write." This personal, affectionate way of teaching reflects the Indian tradition of *guru-shishya* (teacher-disciple). Knowledge is not just information; it is shared with love, guidance, and care.

Therefore, through this letter, Nehru offers a deeper understanding of Indian culture and civilization. He shows the Indian spirit of joy in suffering, the vision of history as continuity, the balance of inner and outer knowledge, the harmony of spirituality and science, the concern for ethical use of power, and the personal way of teaching. His reflections are rooted in India but also open to the world. As he says, man's quest is endless, and civilization grows by this quest. In this way, Nehru gives his daughter, and us, both a historical lesson and a cultural philosophy.

2. Bill Aitken shows a sympathetic understanding of the North–South cultural differences in “Travels by a Lesser Line”. Discuss.

Bill Aitken in *Travels by a Lesser Line* shows a sympathetic understanding of the cultural differences between the North and the South of India. The travelogue follows his journey on the metre gauge railway from the far corners of the country. Through vivid description and gentle humour, Aitken highlights how people from different regions behave, speak, and think. At the same time, he avoids harsh judgment. Instead, he observes with affection and empathy, presenting India’s cultural diversity as a source of richness.

To begin with, Aitken carefully describes the landscape and spiritual setting of Tiruchendur, a temple town in Tamil Nadu. The white gopuram of the temple, “almost on the shore,” with the “giant hour-hand of a clock affixed in neon lights,” shows how South Indian temple culture blends tradition with modern imagery. The temple is not only a religious site but also a symbol of the resilience of South Indian devotion. By comparing the lance of Lord Murugan with the hour-hand of a clock, Aitken connects northern railway imagery with southern temple architecture. This shows his ability to unite two cultural worlds through sympathetic imagination.

Furthermore, Aitken narrates his experience on a Tamil Nadu bus where northern pilgrims clashed with the southern staff. The conflict arises from different habits. The northern passengers were anxious about their luggage on the bus roof getting wet in the rain, while the conductor casually assured them, “If it rains, you can report me.” The north Indians also resented paying “25 paise every time” to use toilets, which they considered unnecessary because they came from the “free-peeing North.”

On the other hand, the southern driver annoyed the passengers by spitting frequently, described humorously as “a great gobber, who marked each furlong with the discharge of spit.” These observations could have been presented critically. However, Aitken handles them lightly, showing that such differences are more about human habits than serious divisions. His sympathy lies in the way he laughs with, not at, both sides.

Moreover, Aitken pays attention to values of punctuality and discipline in the South. He explains that Tamil bus crews strictly follow the five-minute rule for halts, while northern travellers assume it could extend to fifteen minutes. The resulting quarrels are narrated without bitterness. Instead, Aitken views them as daily dramas of cultural interaction. By calling them “verbal warfare,” he exaggerates humorously but also reveals the depth of misunderstanding between regions. Still, he concludes that these incidents only add colour to the travel experience.

In addition, Aitken finds unity in diversity through the spiritual appeal of South Indian temples. Tiruchendur, known as “The Abode of Fulfilment,” attracts pilgrims from all over India. North Indians and South Indians, Ayappa devotees and Murugan worshippers, all meet on the same beach and in the same temple. Aitken notes that these casteless attractions show the resilience of Hindu culture. The cultural chasm between North and South is bridged here by faith. His sympathetic tone emerges in the way he presents the temple as a spiritual holiday resort, where devotion and enjoyment exist together.

Also, Aitken uses the railway itself as a metaphor for unity. He writes that “the elation one had felt at the start of one’s journey on the Brahmaputra was echoed exactly in the pounding of the waves at Tiruchendur, though the cultural chasm between the two is enormous.” The metre gauge railway thus shrinks distance and creates “an alchemical union of opposites.” This remark shows his deep sympathy for the cultural differences of India, because he sees them not as barriers but as contrasts that enrich the nation.

Finally, Aitken’s prose style confirms his sympathetic approach. He avoids heavy criticism and instead uses gentle humour. His description of the north Indians as “passengers from the free-peeing North” and the Tamil driver as a “great gobber” is playful, not insulting. He also admires the efficiency of the southern railway system, describing it as “leisure all the way.” The humour, combined with admiration, makes his travelogue balanced and compassionate.

Therefore, Bill Aitken in *Travels by a Lesser Line* demonstrates sympathetic understanding of the North–South cultural differences. By observing daily quarrels, temple rituals, and railway journeys with humour and affection, he reveals the richness of Indian diversity. His writing celebrates both the cultural gap and the unity created by shared journeys and spiritual traditions. As he concludes, “the outstanding memory of this MG quartering had been my constant intoxication at the sheer wonder India still is.” This statement sums up his sympathetic vision, where difference becomes a source of delight rather than division.

3. What are the key features of Margaret Laurence’s speech “My Final Hour” that make it thought-provoking? Illustrate your answer with relevant examples from the text.

The speech “*My Final Hour*” by Margaret Laurence is thought-provoking because it combines personal honesty, social concern, and moral urgency. The speech does not only present her fears and hopes but also compels the audience to think about their own responsibility towards humanity. The following features make this speech powerful and memorable.

The first feature is **personal tone and humility**. Laurence begins her address by admitting her nervousness and her need for something “solid to lean on, physically, but also...spiritual.” This honesty makes her words relatable because she does not speak as a distant intellectual but as a human being who shares limitations. She even jokes gently about feeling “stupider” with age, which she connects to “healthy humility.” This personal tone makes the audience trust her sincerity.

The second feature is **acceptance of human limitations alongside responsibility**. Laurence accepts that she cannot master every subject or write the perfect novel, yet she insists that “an acceptance of limitations does not mean...an acceptance of defeat.” By saying this, she encourages listeners to extend their boundaries and struggle for justice despite weaknesses. The connective idea here is that recognizing limits can lead to greater courage.

The third feature is **moral radicalism with age**. She says, “as we grow older we should become not less radical but more so.” This thought is striking because many people think activism belongs only to the young. Laurence challenges this belief by arguing that concern for justice is a lifelong duty. Her words provoke the audience to rethink their role, especially as future clergymen, in continuing the struggle for a better world.

The fourth feature is **emphasis on universal responsibility**. Laurence highlights that the danger of nuclear war is not limited to one nation. She says clearly, “there are not two sides” because in a nuclear conflict there would be no winners, only destruction. This argument forces the audience to imagine the global scale of disaster. By linking the nuclear issue with “the needless suffering in the world,” such as malaria and poverty, she shows that misplaced priorities cause avoidable deaths.

The fifth feature is the use of **historical memory as a warning**. Laurence recalls Hiroshima and Nagasaki and connects them with the Holocaust. She reminds her audience that “after Hiroshima, August 6th, 1945, the world would never be the same again.” She calls the complacency of leaders who talk of “limited nuclear war” as nothing but “Evil.” This strong word shocks the listeners and urges them to see the seriousness of language used by militarists.

The sixth feature is **powerful use of imagination and empathy**. Laurence insists that leaders lack imagination because they cannot visualize the suffering of “scorched and charred bodies of children.” She argues that all children are “our children” whether they are Canadian, Russian, or from anywhere else. This emotional appeal awakens compassion and challenges the cold language of “megadeath” and “overkill.”

The seventh feature is the connection of **global issues with personal experience**. Laurence recalls seeing children dying of thirst in Somaliland and children suffering from malaria in

Ghana, including her own two children. She contrasts this reality with the wasteful cost of a Trident submarine. She quotes Dr. Helen Caldicott: “for one third of the cost of a Trident submarine, malaria could be eliminated.” This comparison forces the audience to think about human suffering versus military spending.

The eighth feature is **appeal to action and responsibility**. Laurence warns against “psychic numbing,” the temptation to ignore horrors. She insists, “We cannot afford passivity. We must take on responsibility for our lives and our world.” These lines push the audience beyond listening into actual commitment.

The final feature is **religious and ethical foundation**. Speaking to theology students, Laurence roots her message in faith. She recalls Christ’s commandment: “Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself.” She affirms belief in the “social gospel” that demands justice, compassion, and peace. By blending Christian teaching with global concerns, she makes the message both spiritual and practical.

The speech “*My Final Hour*” becomes thought-provoking because it is not abstract but filled with humility, memory, empathy, and urgency. The personal stories, historical reminders, and moral challenges invite the audience to rethink their place in a hurting world. The key lesson is that every human being, regardless of age or limitation, carries responsibility for peace, justice, and life itself.

4. Who is the narrator of the story “Mother”? Discuss his character in detail with relevant examples from the text.

The narrator of **Judah Waten’s** short story *Mother* is the son of the central character, his mother. The story is told in the **first person**, which allows the reader to see events and understand the mother’s character through the eyes of her child.

The narrator is observant, reflective, and deeply aware of his mother’s thoughts, actions, and emotional world. From the beginning, he recalls being “morbidly conscious of Mother’s intent, searching eyes fixed on me,” which shows his sensitivity and acute awareness of his mother’s presence and expectations. This indicates that he is not only a participant in the events but also a thoughtful observer who carefully interprets the people around him.

The narrator’s character is **empathetic and introspective**. He perceives that his mother’s attention is not on his minor daily deeds but on larger concerns about life and the future. He notes, “She was preoccupied with my sister and me; she was forever concerned with our future in this new land in which she would always feel a stranger.” This shows that he understands her

worries as an immigrant mother trying to secure a meaningful life for her children. The narrator also recognizes the emotional distance between them, admitting, “With me, though I knew she loved me very deeply, she was never on such near terms of friendship as sometimes exist between a mother and son.” His ability to perceive these subtle emotional dynamics makes him a sensitive and perceptive character.

The narrator also demonstrates **loyalty and admiration** towards his mother. He recounts her actions and ideals with respect, noting her determination and moral strength. For example, he remembers how she encouraged him and his sister to pursue education and culture: “She set great aims for us. We were to shine in medicine, in literature, in music; our special sphere depended on her fancy at a particular time.” Through these observations, the narrator reveals his mother’s guiding influence on his life and his deep respect for her ideals.

The narrator is **honest about his own feelings**, sometimes expressing discomfort or embarrassment. When his mother interrupts his play to read to him, he feels “overcome with humiliation and I would stand listlessly with burning cheeks.” Yet he also conveys admiration for her courage and conviction, describing how she confidently argued with shop managers to gain access to music, saying, “Think carefully. Who is right—are they or are we? Why shouldn’t they play for us?” These instances show that the narrator can perceive both the challenges of his mother’s strictness and her admirable determination, portraying her realistically.

The narrator is **historically and culturally aware**, providing details about his mother’s life in Russia, her education, and her experiences in nursing. He recounts, “Somewhere she read of a Jewish hospital which had just opened in a distant city and one winter’s night she told her aunt she wanted to go to relatives who would help her find work in the hospital.” By including such information, the narrator situates his mother within a broader cultural and historical context, showing his attentiveness to the forces that shaped her character.

Finally, the narrator is **reflective about migration and identity**. He observes his mother’s struggle to adjust in Australia and her critical perspective on the new land: “Mother never lost this hostile and ironical attitude to the new land. She would have nothing of the country; she would not even attempt to learn the language.” This demonstrates his awareness of the difficulties faced by immigrants and his insight into his mother’s inner conflict between her ideals and the reality around her.

In conclusion, the narrator of *Mother* is a sensitive, observant, and reflective child who provides a vivid and empathetic portrayal of his mother. He understands her struggles, ideals, and moral strength, while also acknowledging his own emotions and reactions. Through his first-person narration, Waten allows readers to see the mother’s character with depth, highlighting the challenges of migration, cultural adjustment, and the pursuit of ideals in a foreign land.

5. How does Russell portray upper-class life in Victorian Britain through his Autobiography?

The **Autobiography of Bertrand Russell** provides a vivid portrayal of upper-class life in Victorian Britain through his personal recollections and observations. Mostly, Russell reflects on his privileged upbringing, describing the opulent homes, extensive gardens, and leisurely lifestyle that marked his childhood. For example, he remembers spending “the most important hours of my day...alone in the garden,” which emphasizes the freedom afforded to him as a child of an aristocratic family, yet also hints at the isolation that often accompanied wealth.

The detailed attention to natural surroundings, such as tracking “the earliest bluebells” and observing the growth of oaks, indicates not only a love for nature but also the leisurely pace of life enjoyed by the Victorian upper class, where children had time for contemplative activities. Furthermore, Russell portrays the social norms and hierarchies of the era through his interactions with family members. His relationship with his formidable grandmother, Lady Stanley, illustrates the rigid expectations and authority figures in aristocratic households.

The young Russell recounts that she would say, “I have no intelligent grandchildren,” demonstrating both her sternness and the pressures placed on children to meet high standards of intellect and conduct. Similarly, his experiences with governesses and tutors, described with warmth yet subtle irony, reflect the reliance on private education and strict pedagogical practices among the elite. The presence of German and Swiss governesses also suggests the cosmopolitan outlook of upper-class families, who valued continental influence and linguistic skills.

The **Autobiography of Bertrand Russell** also reveals the moral and cultural values of Victorian upper-class society. For instance, Russell’s grandmother’s advice on the commandments shows a pragmatic and unconventional approach to morality: “it is not so bad to break the Seventh Commandment as the Sixth, because at any rate it requires the consent of the other party.” This anecdote provides insight into the contradictions of Victorian ethics, where social propriety often coexisted with private deviations from moral strictness. The detailed recollection of aristocratic social gatherings, visits from political figures such as Gladstone, and interactions with notable personalities like Burne-Jones further underline the exclusivity and formality of upper-class life.

Moreover, Russell highlights the duality of childhood experiences within this class. While he enjoyed access to books, art, and mathematics, he also indulged in playful mischief, as when he dropped “rotten rosebuds out of the gutter onto [the coachman’s] flat top.” These anecdotes show that upper-class children were not only educated but also allowed a degree of freedom and creativity, though always within the framework of social hierarchy.

In addition, Russell's detailed and precise prose captures the environment, routines, and objects that surrounded him, from Pembroke Lodge to the inns and lakes of Perthshire. The attention to objects like the bath chair and the donkey at his uncle's estate illustrates the material abundance available to upper-class children. The Autobiography of Bertrand Russell's rich narrative and use of direct speech, as well as reflective commentary, allow readers to see both the privileges and limitations of this social class.

In conclusion, through his Autobiography, Russell presents upper-class life in Victorian Britain as a combination of privilege, education, formality, and moral rigidity, alongside moments of personal exploration and amusement.
